

Get Ready to Edit

A 30-minute setup to do before the first session (plus download time).

Doing it ahead means Session 1 starts with your first finished photo instead of an installer progress bar. No Photoshop experience needed: just follow the steps.

 ~30 min + download

No Photoshop experience required

Windows or macOS

PLEASE FINISH THIS BEFORE CLASS

Photoshop is a large download, and signing in, installing, and updating can take a while on a slow connection. If you get stuck on any step, that's fine: note where, and we'll help in the first few minutes of Session 1. But please **try** before you arrive.

WHAT YOU NEED

- ◆ A **laptop or desktop** running Windows or macOS that can run the current Photoshop (see **Hardware Notes** below), plus its **charger** if it's a laptop.
- ◆ **Adobe Photoshop 2025 or newer**, the desktop app. The current release is recommended because the generative tools (Session 7) change quickly. Photoshop on the web, on iPad, and Photoshop Elements are **not** enough for this course.
- ◆ An **Adobe account** with a plan that includes Photoshop. A free trial can cover a 4-day intensive but will run out long before an eight-week course ends.
- ◆ A **mouse**. Masking, the Pen tool, and dodge & burn are much harder on a trackpad. A pen tablet is a nice extra, not a requirement.
- ◆ A **notebook or a text file** for your learning journal.
- ◆ **Some of your own photos** (see **What Photos to Bring**). Practice files are provided for every lab, so you are never stuck without one.

SET UP IN 5 STEPS

1 Install Photoshop through Creative Cloud

~10 min + download

- 1 Go to **adobe.com**, sign in (or create a free Adobe account), and choose a plan that includes Photoshop, or start a trial.
- 2 Download and run the **Creative Cloud desktop app**. Sign in with the same Adobe account.
- 3 In Creative Cloud, find **Photoshop** under **Apps** and click **Install**. Let it finish, including any updates it offers.
- 4 Open Photoshop once. If it asks you to sign in or accept terms, do it now, not in class.
- 5 Check your version: **Help ► About Photoshop** (Windows) or **Photoshop ► About Photoshop** (macOS). It should say **2025** or newer. If not, update from Creative Cloud: **Apps ► Updates**.

WHAT IS CREATIVE CLOUD?

It's Adobe's installer and updater. It keeps Photoshop current and manages your sign-in. Leave it installed; you'll use it to update Photoshop during the course.

2 Reset the workspace

~3 min

Everyone starting from the same screen makes demos easy to follow. If Photoshop has been used on this computer before, this puts the panels back where the lessons expect them.

- 1 Choose **Window ► Workspace ► Essentials (Default)**.
- 2 Then choose **Window ► Workspace ► Reset Essentials**.
- 3 Make sure you can see the **Layers** panel at the bottom right. If not: **Window ► Layers** (or press **F7**).

SHARED OR BORROWED COMPUTER?

If tools behave strangely (odd brush settings, missing menus), reset Photoshop's preferences: **Preferences ► General ► Reset Preferences On Quit**, then quit and reopen Photoshop. This only resets settings; it never touches your files.

Open Preferences: **Edit** ► **Preferences** ► **General** (Windows) or **Photoshop** ► **Settings** ► **General** (macOS; older versions say **Preferences**). Then visit these sections in the list on the left:

- ◆ **File Handling:** turn on **Automatically Save Recovery Information Every 10 Minutes**. If your version offers a **default file location**, set it to **your computer** (the course saves working files as `.psd` on your own drive, not as cloud documents).
- ◆ **Performance:** let Photoshop use about **70%** of your memory (the default is usually fine), and set **History States** to at least **50** so you can step back further.
- ◆ **Units & Rulers:** set Rulers to **Pixels**.
- ◆ **Interface:** if text looks small, raise the **UI Font Size** or **UI Scaling** (takes effect after a restart). Any color theme is fine.

WINDOWS VS MAC KEYS

The course writes shortcuts as **Ctrl/⌘** and **Alt/⌥**: use Ctrl and Alt on Windows, ⌘ Command and ⌥ Option on a Mac.

4

Create a course folder

~5 min

Every lesson has you keep two kinds of files: a layered `.psd` master you can keep editing, and a flat `.jpg` you share. A tidy folder keeps them, and your untouched originals, apart.

```
photoshop-course/  
├─ originals/      ← copies of your photos; never edit these  
├─ session-1/      ← working .psd files and exports for Session 1  
├─ session-2/  
├─ ...  
├─ session-8/  
└─ journal.txt     ← or a paper notebook
```

ONE RULE THAT SAVES HEADACHES

Always work on **copies**. Put copies of your photos in `originals/`, and never overwrite them. Name files in lowercase with hyphens, the way the lessons do (`myphoto-working.psd` , `myphoto-final.jpg`).

5

Confirm it all works

~5 min

- 1 In Photoshop, **File ► Open** any photo from your `originals/` folder.
- 2 Check that the photo appears in the **Layers** panel as a layer named **Background**.
- 3 **File ► Save As**, choose **Photoshop (.psd)**, and save it into `session-1/` as `test-working.psd`. If Photoshop asks where to save, choose **Save on your computer**.
- 4 Open the **Edit** menu and look for **Generative Fill** (it will be grayed out until you make a selection; that's normal). If you can't find it at all, tell us before Session 7.
- 5 Close the file.

✓ YOU'RE READY

If you saved a `.psd` to your own folder, you're completely set up for Session 1. If anything didn't work, note which step and we'll sort it out in the first few minutes of class.

WHAT PHOTOS TO BRING

Practice files are provided for every lab, but the course is more fun (and your portfolio better) with your own pictures. Phone photos are perfect. Bring **copies**, at their full original size, not screenshots or images saved from social media.

SESSION	BRING	WHY
S1	One everyday photo that's a little dark or a little crooked	Your first fix & export
S2	A landscape with a clear sky; a photo with one clear subject (a person, pet, or product); a "messy" photo with dust, a sign, or a stray tourist	Masks, selections, cleanup
S3	A flat or off-color photo: an overcast day or an indoor shot. A RAW file is welcome but not required	Camera Raw & Curves
S4	A portrait of someone who has agreed to be retouched and shown in class. A self-portrait works. Close enough to see skin detail	Natural retouching
S5	Two images: a subject (person, pet, or product) shot full-length against a plain-ish background, and a background scene with a clear light direction (visible shadows) to place it in	Compositing
S6	Optional: a photo for your poster's hero image (your Session 5 composite works well), and the words for a real or imaginary event	Poster design
S7	A photo with a distraction and some open space; a tightly cropped or vertical photo; a folder of 10–20 photo copies for batch processing	Generative tools & automation
S8	Your capstone file, planned and mostly built as homework after Session 7	Present & ship

CONSENT AND RIGHTS

Only retouch or show people who have said yes, or yourself. Avoid photos of strangers, and of children who aren't yours. Don't bring confidential or client work. For your capstone, use images you took yourself or have the right to use.

HARDWARE NOTES

- ◆ **Check Adobe's current system requirements** for Photoshop before you buy or install anything. They change with each release.
- ◆ **Memory:** 16 GB of RAM makes a real difference once files have many layers; 8 GB will work but may feel slow in Sessions 4, 5, and 8.

- ◆ **Disk space:** keep plenty of free space (20 GB or more) on your main drive. Photoshop uses it as a scratch disk while you work.
- ◆ **Graphics:** update your graphics drivers. Several tools (and smooth zooming) rely on the GPU.
- ◆ **Screen:** a display of 1920 × 1080 or larger helps; panels get crowded on small laptop screens.
- ◆ **Color:** turn off **Night Light** (Windows) or **Night Shift / True Tone** (macOS) during class. They tint your screen and will mislead your color decisions.
- ◆ **Chromebooks and tablets** can't run desktop Photoshop. Contact us first if that's all you have.

ACCESSIBILITY

Tell us before Session 1 if anything would make the course easier for you. A few things that already help:

- ◆ **Bigger interface:** raise UI Font Size or UI Scaling in Preferences ► Interface (step 3).
- ◆ **Color vision differences:** the lessons lean on checks you can see, not just color names (toggling a layer's eye, before/after comparisons, the squint test). The **Info** panel (**Window ► Info**) shows exact color numbers under your cursor, and **View ► Proof Setup** includes color-blindness previews.
- ◆ **Keyboard over precise mousing:** most tools have single-key shortcuts, collected in the lessons' recipe cards and the online Recipes library.
- ◆ **Screen readers:** Photoshop is a highly visual app with limited screen-reader support. Please talk to us so we can plan alternatives together.
- ◆ **Pace and breaks:** every session has a break, and every lesson stays online, in light or dark mode, to revisit at your own speed.

FREQUENTLY ASKED

◆ DO I NEED TO BE GOOD AT COMPUTERS, OR AT ART?

No. If you can find a photo on your drive and manage folders, you're ready. Session 1 starts with one small, finished win and builds from there.

◆ CAN I USE AN OLDER PHOTOSHOP OR PHOTOSHOP ELEMENTS?

Please don't. Older versions lack tools the lessons use (like the Remove tool and the generative features), and Elements lacks many core features. Photoshop 2025 or newer, current release preferred.

◆ WHAT ARE GENERATIVE CREDITS?

Generative Fill and Expand run in Adobe's cloud and use credits that come with most Photoshop plans. Check your balance in your Adobe account before Session 7. School or company accounts sometimes have generative features turned off by an administrator; check early if yours is one.

◆ DO I NEED A PEN TABLET?

No. A mouse is plenty. A tablet makes retouching and masking feel more natural, but everything in the course works without one.

◆ WHAT IF I CAN'T FINISH THE SETUP?

Come anyway. Note where you got stuck; we'll help you in the first few minutes so you're editing with everyone else.